

Music education: where to start

Certificate in Music Education · fall 2027 entry



Music education
page

Certificate	Length	Taken with	Contact
Certificate in Music Education	31 units, two-year rotation	The B.A., the M.A., or on its own	John Eros, Music Education Coordinator

01 The certificate

The certificate is the subject matter portion of becoming a music teacher in California. Completing it satisfies the subject matter requirement for the California Single Subject Teaching Credential in Music without a separate examination. The credential itself is a separate program run by the School of Education, and it authorizes teaching any area of music from kindergarten through high school.

The 31 units cover music education (world music, foundations, technology, and a practicum), basic and intermediate conducting, secondary techniques in strings, woodwinds, brass, percussion, guitar, and voice, and elementary, instrumental, and choral teaching methods. Students complete observation and teaching hours in Bay Area classrooms. The courses are offered on a two-year rotation. Stand-alone certificate students can take applied lessons after a successful placement audition.



Certificate
roadmap

02 Three ways to take it

With the B.A. in Music. Apply to the B.A. and add the certificate once you're admitted. Several certificate courses also count as B.A. music electives.

With the M.A. in Music. Admission to the M.A. makes you eligible to begin the certificate, which you complete alongside the degree.

On its own, if you already hold a bachelor's degree. You apply directly through Cal State Apply.

03 Financial aid

Taken on its own, the certificate isn't eligible for federal or state financial aid. Taken with the B.A. or the M.A., it is. Without a bachelor's degree, or with one in a field other than music, that route is the B.A. With a bachelor's in music, it's the M.A. Write to the Graduate Coordinator before you decide.

04 The degrees

The B.A. in Music is 120 units of applied lessons, ensembles, and coursework across performance, composition, music technology, jazz, and music education. Transfer students with the Associate Degree for Transfer in Music complete it in two years.

The M.A. in Music is 32 units over four semesters, in Performance (Classical or Jazz), Choral Conducting, or Composition.



B.A. in Music page



M.A. in Music page

05 Applying for the stand-alone certificate

1. Apply to Cal State East Bay through Cal State Apply, choosing the Certificate in Music Education.
2. Submit the Department's materials in Cal State Apply:
 - a CV or résumé
 - two letters of recommendation from people who can speak to your readiness to teach music (you enter their names and email addresses, and each receives a form and an upload link)
 - a statement of purpose, 2 to 3 double-spaced pages, on your background in music and why you want to teach K-12
 - unofficial transcripts from every school you've attended
3. Ask every college and university you've attended to send official transcripts to the Office of Admissions, electronically to electronictranscripts@csueastbay.edu.
4. Check the graduate and credential application and document deadlines for the term you're applying to.

B.A. and M.A. applicants follow their degree's application instead.



Cal State Apply



Transcripts and documents



Graduate deadlines

06 The teaching credential

The Single Subject Teaching Credential is a separate program with its own application, run by the School of Education. The certificate covers the subject matter requirement for it.



Single Subject Credential

07 Visit and contacts

Sit in on a class, hear a rehearsal, and meet the faculty. Write to the Music Education Coordinator to arrange a visit.

Office	Contact
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